

Lucas Castillo



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Education

- 2021 – 2025 **Ph.D. in Psychology** UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK.
Supervisor: Prof. Adam Sanborn
Thesis title: *A Local Sampling Account of Random Generation* (📄)
- Jul-Sep 2024 **Research visit** at UNIVERSITY OF HAMBURG, Germany
under the supervision of Prof. Sebastian Gluth.
- 2019 – 2020 **M.Sc. Cognitive and Decision Sciences** UNIVERSITY COLLEGE LONDON, UK
Dissertation title: *Does newly learned causal knowledge guide the perception of temporal order?*
- 2012 – 2016 **B.Sc. Psychology** UNIVERSIDAD DE SEVILLA, Spain.

Employment

- January 2026 - Present **Research Fellow**, UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, United Kingdom.
ESRC-funded project developing a single cognitive model that explains behaviour across several tasks.
- July – September 2024 **Predoctoral Researcher**, UNIVERSITY OF HAMBURG, Germany.
Carried out research project under the supervision of Prof. Sebastian Gluth.
- 2023 – 2024 **Research Assistant**, UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, United Kingdom.
Continued development of *samplr* **R Package**.
- 2021 – 2023 **Teaching Assistant**, UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, United Kingdom.
Assisted teaching of two **statistics modules** (frequentist and Bayesian) at MSc level.
- 2020 – 2021 **Research Assistant**, UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, United Kingdom.
Started the *samplr* **R Package**, developed **lab website**, and carried out own research.

Acquired Funding

- 2025 **Enhancing Research Fund (£2860)** UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK
(Co-applicant). Purpose: Organizing open research workshops aimed at Early Career Researchers.
- Behaviour Spotlight Small Grant Scheme (£2000)** UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK
(Co-applicant). Project: *Rumination and Random Generation*
- 2024 **Behaviour Spotlight Small Grant Scheme (£2000)** UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK
(Co-applicant). Project: *Exploration Behaviour in Decisions from Experience*

Publications

Journal Articles

- 4 **Castillo, L.,** León-Villagrà, P., Falbén, J. K., Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2026). *Random Generation is What Comes to Mind in Naturalistic Settings*. *Cognition*, 274, 106554.
🔗 <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2026.106554>

Publications (continued)

- 3 Spicer, J., Li, Y.-X., **Castillo, L.**, Falbén, J. K., Qian, C. S., & Sanborn, A. N. (2026). Generated Outcomes in Risky Choice Reveal Biased Sampling and Sequential Dependencies. *Communications Psychology*. In Press.
- 2 Sanborn, A. N., Zhu, J.-Q., Spicer, J., León-Villagrà, P., **Castillo, L.**, Falbén, J. K., Li, Y.-X., Tee, A., & Chater, N. (2025). Noise in Cognition: Bug or Feature? *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 20(3), 572–589. <https://doi.org/10.1177/17456916241258951>
- 1 **Castillo, L.**, León-Villagrà, P., Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2024). Explaining the flaws in human random generation as local sampling with momentum. *PLOS Computational Biology*, 20(1), 1–24. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pcbi.1011739>

Preprints

- 6 **Castillo, L.**, León-Villagrà, P., Falbén, J. K., Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2025). *People Need a Few Seconds to Be Random*. PsyArXiv. <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/awg9j>
- 5 **Castillo, L.**, Li, Y.-X., & Sanborn, A. N. (2025). *The samplr package: A tool for modeling human cognition with sampling algorithms*. PsyArXiv. <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/ax8hm>
- 4 Spicer, J., Li, Y.-X., **Castillo, L.**, Falben, J., Qian, S., & Sanborn, A. N. (2025). *Mental Sampling in Preferential Choice: Tracing the Process using Random Generation*. PsyArXiv. <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/kzmb5>
- 3 Li, Y.-X., Falben, J., **Castillo, L.**, Spicer, J., Zhu, J.-Q., Qian, S., Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2025). *Does utility bias mental simulations of risky events?* PsyArXiv. <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/awdr7>
- 2 Falbén, J., **Castillo, L.**, León-Villagrà, P., Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2024). *Biased mind or biased world? Assessing the accuracy of cultural beliefs that underlie social judgments*. PsyArXiv. <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/5hdbp>
- 1 León-Villagrà, P., **Castillo, L.**, Falbén, J., Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2024). *Eliciting Beliefs with Random Generation Tasks*. <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/687au>

Peer-reviewed Conference Proceedings Articles

- 4 Valentin, S.[†], **Castillo, L.**[†], Sanborn, A. N., & Lucas, C. G. (2024). Distinguishing Between Process Models of Causal Learning. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, 46. <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/2p43j2cw>
- 3 Li, Y.-X., Falbén, J. K., **Castillo, L.**, Spicer, J., Zhu, J.-Q., Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2024). Probability, but not utility, influences repeated mental simulations of lotteries. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, 46. <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/2ps2t4sz>
- 2 León-Villagrà, P., **Castillo, L.**, Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2022). Eliciting Human Beliefs using Random Generation. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, 44. <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/88k526dj>
- 1 **Castillo, L.**, León-Villagrà, P., Chater, N., & Sanborn, A. N. (2021). Local Sampling with Momentum Accounts for Human Random Sequence Generation. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, 43. <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/3gz154kg>

† = equal contribution

Conferences

Workshops

- July 2026 **Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society** *Autocorrelated Sampling in Cognition: Implementing MCMC Models and Fitting Them Without Likelihoods*

Conferences (continued)

Talks

September 2026	European Mathematical Psychology Group Meeting <i>Autocorrelated Sampling in Cognition: Implementing MCMC Models and Fitting Them Without Likelihoods</i>
July 2024	MathPsych <i>Characterizing People's Sampling Engines Using Random Generation</i>
August 2023	SPUDM <i>Production rate effects on random generation elicitation</i>
July 2023	MathPsych <i>Modelling speeded random generation as sampling for inference.</i>
July 2022	Virtual MathPsych <i>Using sampling algorithms to explain human random generation.</i>
October 2021	Computational Cognition Workshop <i>Human random generation as a locally-bound process.</i>

Poster Presentations

July 2024	Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society <i>People Need About Five Seconds to be Random: Autocorrelated Sampling Algorithms Can Explain Why</i>
November 2021	Annual Meeting of the Psychonomic Society <i>Local sampling can explain human deviations from randomness.</i>
July 2021	Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society <i>Local sampling with momentum accounts for human random sequence generation.</i>

Other

July 2026	Summer school in Cognitive Modeling & Simulation-Based Inference. Columbus OH, USA
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Reviews

Since	Venue	Count
Journals		
2026	Cognition	1
2026	Psychological Review	1
2024	Journal of Experimental Psychology: General	2
2023	Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory, and Cognition	1
Conferences		
2024	Cogsci Conference	16
2023	SPUDM Conference	5
Other		
2026	Psychological Science (Computational Reproducibility Check)	2

Misc.

Other Outputs

R Packages	Castillo, L., Li, Y.-X., & Sanborn, A. N. (2024). samplr: Compare Human Performance to Sampling Algorithms. https://CRAN.R-project.org/package=samplr
	Castillo, L., Li, Y.-X., & Sanborn, A. N. (2024). samplrData: Datasets from the SAMPLING Project. https://CRAN.R-project.org/package=samplrData .

Misc. (continued)

Other University Involvement

2024 – present	Member of ReproducibiliTea Organizing Committee at UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK (University-wide Open Research initiative)
2022 – 2023	Student Representative for Psychology PhD Students at UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK
2021 – 2023	Teaching Assistant , UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK. Modules: <i>Methods and Analysis in Behavioural Science</i> and <i>Bayesian Approaches in Behavioural Science</i>
2019 – 2020	Student Representative for M.Sc. Cognitive and Decision Sciences cohort at UNIVERSITY COLLEGE LONDON, UK

Awards and Scholarships

2025	Best PhD Student Paper DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY, UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK. <i>Granted for Castillo et al. 2024.</i>
2021	Departmental PhD Scholarship DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY, UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK, UK
2020	Best performing student of the academic year for the MSc in Cognitive and Decision Sciences, UNIVERSITY COLLEGE LONDON, UK.

Skills

Languages	Spanish (mother tongue), Catalan, English (fluent), French, German (learning!)
Coding	git, Python, R, C++, $\LaTeX$, HTML, css, JavaScript, REACTJS.

References

Available upon request